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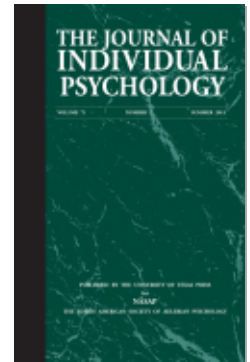
Generation Z: Technology and Social Interest

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The Journal of Individual Psychology, Volume 71, Number 2, Summer 2015,
pp. 103-113 (Article)

Published by University of Texas Press

DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1353/jip.2015.0021>



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Generation Z: Technology and Social Interest

Anthony Turner

Abstract

The article explores Generation Z, its special relationship with technology and social media, and its values, as well as how this generation may form and practice social interest. The author shares recommendations for parents, teachers, and clinicians.

Keywords: Individual Psychology, Generation Z, Adlerian, youth, social media, social interest, technology, parenting

Social interest (or *Gemeinschaftsgefühl*) is one of Alfred Adler's most distinct concepts. The theory states that social interest is innate to humans, as it is a necessary foundation for the development of an individual while also advancing the evolution of humans (Adler, 1979). Because humans are hardwired to want connection with one another, how does this connection work with Generation Z?

A generation is defined as "a set of historical events and related phenomena that creates a distinct generational gap" (Parry & Urwin, 2011). According to Parry and Urwin (2011), the identification of a generation requires "some form of social 'proximity' to shared events or cultural phenomenon" (p. 84). The intention of this article is to take an in-depth look at the role of technology and how use of technology can affect prosocial interest in Generation Z.

The Living Generations

In American culture currently, there are, as defined by a 2010 Pew Research study (Taylor & Keeter, 2010), four generations of legal adults. The four adult generations, according to the Pew study, include the silent generation (traditionalists or the Greatest Generation: those born between 1922 and 1945), the baby boomers (born from 1946 to 1964); Generation X (born from 1965 to 1977); and millennials (born from about 1977 to 1993). In addition, there is Generation Z (born from 1993 to 2005). The focus of this article is on Generation Z, the oldest of whom are now reaching young adulthood, and the majority of whom are between age 20 and younger.

Generation Z's Unique Features

Generation Z, along with I-generation, net-gen, and digital natives, describe youth born in the mid-1990s through the late 2010s. Generation Z includes the current youth of American society. According to Prensky (2001), contemporary youth are digital natives, because they never experienced life before the Internet. No other generation has lived in an era in which technology is so readily accessible at such a young age (Prensky, 2001). With technological advances in multimedia, such as tablets, the smartphone (which combines cell phone, media player, cameras, and Internet capabilities into one device), social media, and flat-screen televisions, Generation Z youth have become accustomed to interacting and communicating in a world that is connected at all times.

Generation Z youth are uniquely diverse, with biracial and multiracial children being the fastest-growing segments in the United States (American Academy of Child and Adolescent Psychiatry, 2011). The LGBTQ community continues to grow through Generation Z, as the secrecy associated with sexual orientation is not as prominent as in previous generations. More Generation Z youth are being raised in urban areas, leading to more people within that generation being exposed to a plethora of cultural perspectives, as compared to previous generations (Tacoli, 2012).

Generation Z youth have been affected by the growing income gap and shrinking middle class. Stress levels at home increased dramatically during the national recession that can be traced to the financial crisis of 2008, when subprime mortgage lending led to a global economic crisis and sky-high unemployment numbers. The income gap continues to widen, and Generation Z youth with educated parents not only are dealing with their own loan repayment challenges but also are witnessing their parents experiencing financial stressors due to the financial crisis. These stressors have the potential to affect parental responses to behaviors, thus sometimes causing harsher parenting practices. The financial hardships in the homes of many Generation Z youth might have led them to be highly conscious of the importance of money, and so saving might be of high importance to them (TD Ameritrade, 2012).

Generation Z youth have been reared during a time of war. The oldest individuals of Generation Z were approximately 7- or 8-year-olds during the terrorist attacks of September 11, 2001 (Tulgan, 2012). These attacks eventually led to the war in Afghanistan, which persists to this day. The Iraq War also started in 2003. Thousands of Generation Z children of military parents have experienced the consequences of these two wars, as parents have been injured or killed in the line of duty. The wars in Iraq and Afghanistan, whether directly or indirectly, influence the way Generation Z youth view

the world. As a group raised in constant war, contemporary youth may view the world with the belief that the world is “unsafe,” yet at the same time, they may have greater global awareness as a result. These events have resulted in a generation that potentially values fiscal responsibility, tolerance of others, education, employment flexibility, and networking abilities. However, the most significant factor to consider here is digital natives’ use of technology. No generation has demonstrated a level of proficiency or comfort with technology at such an early age as Generation Z (Palley, 2012). The impact of technology on this and subsequent generations, both positive and negative, should not be overlooked.

Strengths of Technology

According to Toronto (2009), the Internet has become a defining characteristic of the global society. Since the 1990s and its wave of technological advancement, the Internet has played a distinctive role in the lives of Generation Z youth. Toronto (2009) also underscored how the flood of information and resources provided by revolutionary technological advancements has altered the way people conduct business, maintain contacts, relate as human beings, and access information in a speedy and efficient manner.

Social media has the potential to encourage forums that facilitate both the formation of public opinion and civic participation (Bers, 2010). Computers can be used in very positive ways: to provide an outlet for meeting new people, to share artistic tastes, to keep up with family and friends across the globe, to mobilize civic protests, to find romantic partners, and even to gain therapeutic support through online and e-mail therapy (Bers, 2010). Teachers are using technological resources to enhance classroom-learning experiences (Xiaoqing, Yuankun, & Xiaofeng, 2013). These educators continue to increase access to technological devices, such as the iPad, because of their mobility and multitasking capabilities (Pilgrim, Bledsoe, & Reily, 2012).

Generation Z and Technology Use: **Review of the Kaiser Family Foundation Study**

Generation Z youth have been reared in the first truly mobile era (Palley, 2012). The amount of media use of respondents aged 8–18 reached epic proportions, as evidenced by surveys of 2,000 Generation Z youth. The Rideout, Foehr, and Roberts study conducted for the Kaiser Family Foundation (2010) reports that Generation Z youth are exposed to media

more than to any other activity besides sleeping, with a 67 minutes per day increase in the amount of time spent by participants consuming and interacting with media in 2009, as compared to 2004. When accounting for multitasking, this number is now approaching 8 hours of total electronic multimedia exposure daily. The study attributed the explosion of usage to the online and mobile media revolution, concluding that the transformation of the smartphone platform, which delivers multimedia content, played a major role in the increased time spent on devices.

The Smartphone

Individuals no longer need to watch or interact with one device at a time. A decade ago, individuals could watch a television show on a television, listen to music on a computer or MP3 player (or CD player), and play a video game on a console. Now, these formats are all accessible in one handheld device that is portable and small enough to fit in one's pocket: the smartphone. The smartphone allows all of these forms of media to be enacted almost simultaneously. Contemporary youth who own smartphones literally and figuratively have the world in their hands. For Generation Z youth, the smartphone is an "everything" hub of entertainment (Palley, 2012).

Demographic Considerations

The degree of phone use is not limited to rich children with all-inclusive data plans. In the Kaiser Family Foundation (2010) survey, almost 60% of respondents who lived in households where parents earn a median income of less than \$30,000 a year also owned a cell phone. Thus, cell phone use is not necessarily exclusive to the "haves"; "have-nots" are also gaining access to this technology (Rideout et al., 2010). Another interesting demographic note from the study shows that Latino and African American Generation Z youth consume 4.5 more media hours each day than White youth (Rideout et al., 2010). Rideout et al. (2010) noted that minority Generation Z youth live in homes where the TV is more likely to be left on when no one is watching, and they report higher instances of the TV being on during meals than for White youth. The Kaiser Family Foundation (2010) study does not provide an explanation for these dramatic differences. However, a question to consider centers on income inequality, race, and educational resources (or lack thereof). Which factors help explain the differences between race/ethnicity when it comes to media use among Generation Z youth? Do the voids left by cuts in arts, sports, and music programs in low-income school districts mean that young people instead fill their time with media use? When taking into account the higher numbers of minorities who are raised in single-parent households (nearly 67% of African American children are raised in single-parent families, compared to 25% of White children), an

overall lack of time for parents to monitor media use may also provide a possible explanation for discrepancies (Annie E. Casey Foundation, 2013).

Attachment to Devices

Generation Z has formed such a digital bond to the Internet that they identify feeling emotionally attached to it, with more than 90% of participants indicating that they would be upset about having to give up an Internet connection as a punishment, according to a survey of Generation Z youth between age 13 to age 17 conducted by Palley (2012). Participants reported that they would feel more upset when forced to give up cell phones or texting friends than with punishments such as not receiving allowance money or not being allowed to buy new video games (Palley, 2012). In Palley's (2012) study, offline activities, such as going to the movies, attending a sports event, or going out to eat, ranked significantly lower in comparison to the limits placed on cell phone use.

The majority of Generation Z participants in the Kaiser Family Foundation (2010) study reported not having any rules about the type of media content they could use or the amount of time they could spend using a particular device. When parents do have rules, the most regulated device in Generation Z homes today is the computer: 52% of Generation Z youth report some regulation, according to Rideout et al. (2010). Generation Z reports even less regulation about *time* spent using devices at home. The limits parents place on their children does affect the amount of time they spend engaging with media. According to the Kaiser Family Foundation (2010), children who experienced limits are exposed to almost 3 hours less content per day than youth who report little or no restrictions.

Migration of Media Use

Parents of Generation Z play a large role in the technology boom within households; a typical Generation Z home contains, on average, almost four televisions, three DVD players, a digital video recorder, two CD players, more than two radios, two computers, and at least two video-game consoles on average (Kaiser Family Foundation, 2010). However, where media consumption takes place is migrating. According to Rideout et al. (2010), 71% of young people reported having televisions in their bedrooms, and half of teens surveyed accessed video-game consoles and cable or satellite TV in their bedrooms, adding nearly 1 hour more per day to TV consumption. Generation Z participants can watch television whenever they want. No longer needing to abide by "live" rules, time-shifted television, such as on-demand programming and digital video recording (DVR) capabilities, allows for even more choice than before, and Generation Z is accessing TV programming in a way that is convenient for them and on their own time (Kaiser Family Foundation, 2010).

Social Networks: Facebook's Impact

Initially designed in 2004 as a Harvard student social network, Facebook has had an undeniable impact on how Generation Z youth interact in the world. Close to 60% of Generation Z participants reported that social life begins online; of surveyed youth, 50% reported feeling more comfortable talking to people online than in real life, and 70% reported that it is more convenient to talk with friends online than in real life (Palley, 2012). According to another study of 802 Generation Z youth, teens are sharing more and more about their personal life on Facebook (Taylor & Keeter, 2010). Looking at these statistics, we can assert that Generation Z is fluent in social networking.

The Social Interest and Common Sense of Generation Z

What may seem like too much technology use to one generation is commonplace to another. Oftentimes, studies focus on the quantity of technology use while ignoring the quality of that use (Lei, 2010). When working with Generation Z, it is more important to learn what they are viewing and how that affects their growth and relationships than merely how much time is spent on technology.

High-Frequency Use and Social Interest

Generation Z youth may be using technology so frequently in order to avoid struggles in their offline lives or to find belonging—to fit in—by using escapism and fantasy to fill time and emotional voids (Toronto, 2009). Studies have shown that dopamine released in the limbic system of the brains of video-game players is comparable to levels released in amphetamine users (Weinstein, 2010). The same study attributed excessive amounts of time spent playing video games to an inability to manage frustration, fear, and uneasiness, and to declining grades (Weinstein, 2010), which suggests that youth experiencing these symptoms might be missing out on opportunities to learn coping skills for navigating or tolerating difficult situations. Experiencing these difficulties on a continuous basis, particularly with excessive video gaming, could lead to problems in fulfilling the tasks of love, work, and friendship (Van Rooij, Meerkerk, Schoenmakers, Griffiths, & Van De Mheen, 2010).

Content in Relation to Social Interest

Now more than ever, children can search online for anything they want. Access to pornography, sites that promote self-harm, and sites that teach people how to make weapons are easily accessible, especially to those youth who do not have parental controls. Even with Internet filters, children can view any content they would like on their smartphone. Therefore,

understanding the content of the sites young people are browsing can provide a window into the way they are functioning and the development of their social interest. Although these behaviors existed before the Internet, online capabilities allow for vast access to information that may promote and deepen socially disinterested behaviors.

Decline in Face-to-Face Communication

With technology acting as a go-between for individuals' interactions, society has grown accustomed to being increasingly networked as individuals rather than socially embedded in groups (Rainie & Wellman, 2012). Online connections were first conceived of as a supplement to face-to-face contact; however, society began to perceive face-to-face interactions as impractical (Turkle, 2011). As the volume of social media interactions grows, the social presence and social context of these mediated interactions may be diminishing (Riva, Baños, Botella, Wiederhold, & Gaggioli, 2012). Pea et al.'s (2012) online survey of more than 3,400 North American girls between age 8 and age 12 found that time spent in face-to-face interaction was most closely associated with a wide range of social feelings, as more face-to-face time meant greater social success, greater feelings of normalcy, more hours of sleep, and fewer friends who the children's parents believed were bad influences. Social interest may affect Generation Z youth who are no longer becoming trained in the nuances and art of conversation, and lack of face-to-face communication will potentially inhibit their development of skills to connect socially and in person.

Implications for Human Growth, Development, and Relationships

When Generation Z youth use technology to distract themselves from being in difficult behavioral situations, feeling emotions, or having unpleasant thoughts, do they lose the opportunity to learn healthy coping skills? According to Adler (1930/2011), "Only such persons who are courageous, self-confident, and at home in the world can benefit both by the difficulties and by the advantages of life. They are never afraid. They know that there are difficulties, but they also know that they can overcome them" (p. 39). Adler emphasized the importance of overcoming obstacles as critical to the development of healthy human advancement. Bullying, the need for instant gratification, and distractions associated with continual partial attention are behaviors that, according to Adler, would deviate an individual from his or her ability to develop and practice social interest. A child who doesn't have the opportunity to participate in the process of coping with obstacles and overcoming them in vivo will potentially struggle with relationship development as an adult. Adler's perspective on social interest and the value of learning healthy coping skills to overcome originated long ago, but it is a concept applicable to Generation Z youth today.

Cyberbullying

Generation Z youth constantly deal with cyberbullying, as either (or both) participants or victims (Steyer, 2012). Computer screens and cell phones are safe havens for bullies. Steyer (2012) pointed out that bullies no longer need to look their victims in the eye or deal with their reactions, because the Internet allows for impersonal, impulsive victimization. The Internet seems to cover for the “secret weakness” (Adler, 1930/2011, p. 205) of perpetrators and, thus, for the cruelty to continue. Cyberbullying deviates from social interest and cooperation. The difference between Generation Z cyberbullies and bullies of other generations is that Generation Z no longer sees the immediate physical consequences of—or immediate feedback from—these maladjusted behaviors, because the Internet provides the “safety” of anonymity. The instant and impulsive nature of Internet cyberbullying is a phenomenon entirely unique to Generation Z youth, and it allows for socially disinterested behaviors to proliferate in ways we have never before seen.

Instant Gratification

Generation Z lives in a wired environment and is near their communication devices at all times, which allows them to feel instantly gratified, or hurt, or utterly unimportant, or dismayed by the content or the context of communication—all of these immediately. The time available for young people to sit and think, uninterrupted, has shrunk over the years, as the current culture of communication no longer allows sufficient space to ponder complicated issues (Turkle, 2010). The instantaneous nature of contemporary online communication no longer allows for downtime, daydreams, the ability and/or necessity to manage downtime, and an individual’s ability to identify a single most important issue and focus deeply on it (Turkle, 2011).

Neurological Implications

The high volume of technology consumption has the potential to disrupt neurological development. Hours of television viewing in children aged 1–3 has been linked to a higher risk (10%) of attention problems at age 7 (Steyer, 2012). According to Steyer (2012), Generation Z youth’s lower cognitive regions, which stimulate impulse, are constantly being activated by the bombardment of neurological arousal provided by text messages, Facebook updates, and video games. At the same time, the so-called Google culture of learning—finding answers to any question within seconds—continues to change the way Generation Z youth concentrate, write, and reflect (Steyer, 2012). Although Generation Z youth demonstrate an apparent ease and familiarity with computers, they rely heavily on search engines, “view” rather than read, and may not “uniformly possess” the skills to assess the information they find on the web (Wallis, 2010). Their capacity for linear

thinking has been replaced by a new mode of thinking, in which they need to take in and dish out information in a fast, disjointed, overlapping manner (Wallis, 2010).

Multitasking Versus Continuous Partial Attention

The media and communications explosion has contributed to massive expansion of multitasking behaviors and, as a result, to continuous partial attention. But how much attention can an individual give to more than one task? Continuous partial attention may lead to full engagement in nothing while trying to follow everything—an inefficient and a highly stressful process (Firat, 2013). The term *absent presence*, which means that people may be physically in one place while their social attention and communication focus is elsewhere, is a part of the ever-changing etiquette of rapid technological advances (Rainie & Wellman, 2012).

Recommendations

Using technology to connect with a child may be helpful, but it must be an enhancement instead of a replacement. Clinicians can connect with Generation Z youth not solely by playing a video game but also by asking what the child is learning from the video game. Some example questions include, “How did you learn to get through that level?” “What problem-solving skills did you use?” “How did you feel about yourself when you completed a task?” “What did you learn about yourself after accomplishing the task?” These interventions provide an opportunity for a child to demonstrate strengths and feel empowerment while also allowing the clinician to assess the young person’s views of self, others, and the world.

Gaining deeper awareness of a different generation’s frame of reference will serve to bridge the gap between youth and their parents, teachers, and clinicians who are trying to build relationships with them. An unwillingness to take a different generation’s frame of reference into account can contribute to misunderstanding, miscommunication, and discouragement. It is critical that parents, educators, and clinicians stay actively engaged in the lives of these youth. Providing structure (content and usage limits), promoting responsibility, fostering independence, and encouraging development that emphasizes the importance of coping with the difficulties of life will allow adults to break through generational barriers. It will be possible then to connect on a personal level that allows for the growth of social interest in an individual and advancement of humankind. The explosion of technology is neither good nor bad; it is simply reality. When adults focus on the strengths of technology while also emphasizing continuing the traditions of personal connection, the results can only enhance the social interest for all.

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